

“Being Yourself” Online: Supporting Authenticity for LGBTQ+ Social Media Users

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ABSTRACT

My dissertation work investigates the role of experiencing authenticity and inauthenticity in LGBTQ+ people’s social media behavior. It also asks what sociotechnical factors might support or impede efforts to “be yourself” on social media. In general, people strive to “be themselves,” or feel and act authentically. They seek out environments in which they feel they can express themselves and act according to their values, and avoid environments in which they cannot. For LGBTQ+ people, online spaces in which they can be themselves are particularly crucial, both for personal wellbeing and for forming supportive relationships. However, the drive to “be themselves” is often in tension with the drive to protect themselves from harm. Concerns around privacy and unintended disclosure, harmful experiences with other actors (from both within and without the LGBTQ+ community), and subtle cues embedded in platform design can all contribute to this tension. Through a combination of experimental and deep qualitative research, my dissertation will yield important insight into how marginalized social media users assess and navigate their online environments, and identify opportunities to support vulnerable users.

CCS CONCEPTS

• **Authenticity**; • **Social Identity Threat**; • **LGBTQ+**; • **Technology Ecosystems**;

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1 INTRODUCTION

I investigate how LGBTQ+ social media users take advantage of and are challenged by their social media environments, using authenticity as a lens. I define authenticity as the subjective perception of being the “true, unvarnished ‘me,’” while inauthenticity refers to the sense that one is not being “the real me” [35]. Social media and online fora have emerged as crucial sites for LGBTQ+ people to engage in vulnerable identity exploration [10, 17, 22], find romantic partners [1], connect with community and access social support [12], and ask uncomfortable questions relating to gender

and sexuality [17, 22, 29]. These platforms are only growing in importance as offline community spaces disappear from the urban landscape [15, 25, 28]. Despite the many benefits for LGBTQ+ users, social media continue to be a source of identity-based harms (e.g., [13, 14, 31, 38]). LGBTQ+ social media users continue to be targets of harassment [31, 38] and struggle with managing their self-presentation so as not to appear “too gay” [9, 13]. Moreover, the interfaces of these social technologies are rarely designed with the needs or experiences of marginalized people in mind [5, 37].

Debates about the “realness” of online identities have a long history in the study of social computing (e.g., [23, 36]). My dissertation builds on this work by exploring how subjective experiences of (in)authenticity on social media influence how LGBTQ+ users engage and express themselves across their social media ecosystems. Feeling and acting authentically, in general, has been linked to important wellbeing and prosocial outcomes such as reduced depression and stress [11], high levels of social connectedness [21], and more meaningful and honest self-disclosure [25]. For LGBTQ+ people, additional benefits include positive identity development and greater resilience in the face of discrimination [19]. Because LGBTQ+ people often rely on social platforms for vulnerable self-expression, forming meaningful relationships, and giving and receiving support in times of stress [17], barriers to authenticity are, in effect, barriers to receiving the full benefits offered by social media.

2 RELATED WORK

I draw on literature in social psychology and human-computer interaction (HCI) to inform my work.

In social psychology, social identity threat is one of the most widely-studied concepts of the past 20 years [32]. As a theory, social identity threat seeks to identify how factors in one’s immediate situation contribute to – if not create – the appearance of systematic differences in experience. Social identity threat paints a vivid picture of how people belonging to different social groups may experience the same setting in psychologically distinct ways. More recent work in social psychology (e.g., [33–35]) has examined authenticity and inauthenticity as important psychological outcomes of social identity threat. I draw on social psychology to understand the psychological processes and broader social impacts of social computing technologies, and expand upon investigations of marginalized users’ experiences and concerns.

To translate insights from social psychology into online environments, I turn to HCI literature. HCI has a long history of values as the basis for technology design that addresses the needs of marginalized communities (e.g., [6, 14, 18, 27]). This line of research has highlighted the enormous opportunity of social platforms to

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support marginalized communities, while acknowledging the potential for harm that users might experience [14]. Much of this work has focused on the ways in which marginalized users have been harmed (e.g., [31, 38]), and on what factors influence the disclosure of sensitive self-related information (e.g., [2, 3, 13, 16]). My work contributes to this conversation by exploring how holding an identity that is devalued, in and of itself, might influence how one experiences and interprets their social media environment. Accordingly, my dissertation work asks:

RQ1: What characterizes LGBTQ+ social media users' experiences of authenticity and inauthenticity across their social media ecosystem?

RQ2: How do experiences of authenticity and inauthenticity influence how LGBTQ+ users express themselves on social media platforms?

3 WORK IN PROGRESS

My dissertation consists of two empirical studies – an experiment and a diary study – investigating the barriers to authenticity that LGBTQ+ users might experience. The first study (Experiment) focuses on the role of user-submitted content in lessening sense of belonging and authenticity for potential LGBTQ+ users of a novel social media platform. In the second study (Diary Study), I focus on what factors characterize LGBTQ+ social media users' experiences of authenticity and inauthenticity online. I consider how they navigate the tension between finding utility in social media platforms and protecting themselves against harm.

3.1 Experiment

My experiment asks whether inauthenticity, as an outcome of social identity threat, may be triggered by cues in one's online environment as they are offline. Website elements such as font and masthead image have been demonstrated to cue social identity threat for women considering computer science, even when the content of the website was kept constant [26, 30]. In the case of social media, the visual characteristics of content may be separated from the linguistic/affective content. For instance, a supportive tweet and a hateful tweet may be exactly the same in their aesthetic aspects (e.g., font, color, placement in algorithmic feed), however the effect on the reader may of course differ greatly. Accordingly, my study manipulates the content of user-submitted content arranged in an algorithmic feed while keeping the aesthetic aspects constant.

Specifically, this study considers whether user-submitted content, arranged in a feed as one might encounter on the home page of a social media site, might trigger social identity threat (and a resultant decrease in authenticity) for LGBTQ+ social media users, but not for those who are not LGBTQ+. I employed a 2 (participant identity: LGBTQ+ or not) $\times$ 3 (user-submitted content: supportive, unsupportive, or neutral on LGBTQ+ issues) between-participant experimental design. I hypothesized:

H1: Exposure to user-submitted content that is unsupportive of LGBTQ+ issues significantly predicts decreased authenticity for LGBTQ+ people, compared to LGBTQ+ people exposed to supportive or neutral content, or non-LGBTQ+ people exposed to any content,

H2: Exposure to user-submitted content that is supportive of LGBTQ+ issues significantly predicts increased authenticity for LGBTQ+ people, compared to LGBTQ+ people exposed to unsupportive or neutral content, or non-LGBTQ+ people exposed to any content.

Participants were presented with one of three “home pages” for an ostensible new social media site; these were medium-fidelity wireframes that included 10 “most popular” posts arranged in a feed. Each wireframe contained identical page layouts and were identical in all aesthetic aspects (e.g., colors, fonts). The setup of the ostensible “home page” was similar to many social media sites: content was arranged in a feed, and the header at the top of the page showed the content had been arranged by “Most Popular.” The goal of this layout was to mimic what a potential user might encounter in a new social media environment (e.g., a new subreddit, twitter hashtag, or Facebook group). Participants could click on each post and open the comment section.

All of the posts and comments were copied from real reddit.com posts, with usernames redacted. In the neutral condition, none of the 10 posts mentioned LGBTQ+ identities and issues at all. In the supportive condition, 5 of these posts were replaced with posts from LGBTQ+-supportive subreddits. In the negative condition, the 5 posts were taken from LGBTQ+-unsupportive subreddits. Posts were included if they were over a year old (as of June 2020), did not reference major current events (e.g., elections, legislation), and did not contain hate speech.

After being exposed to one of the three home pages, participants completed a survey to evaluate measures included authenticity and intention to use the site. Analysis of the Experiment data will be complete by the time of the Doctoral Consortium.

3.2 Diary Study

My diary study focuses on a qualitative exploration of what factors characterize LGBTQ+ social media users' experiences of authenticity and inauthenticity online, and how they navigate the tension between finding utility in social media platforms and protecting themselves against harm. In order to help LGBTQ+ people derive the benefits that social media makes possible, we need to first understand what barriers currently exist. I seek to understand what characterizes the moments in which they feel inauthentic (i.e., not like their “true selves”), and authentic (i.e., free to be their “true selves”). Doing so will allow us to identify how devalued social groups attend to and evaluate their social media environments. This in turn will provide a framework for designers to identify and address sources of bias and social identity threat, and opportunities to support minoritized users.

Because I hope to understand day-to-day experiences and behaviors, I am using a diary method. This study will use a feedback diary study approach, in which participants capture each moment on their own time, without prompting on my part [8]. Participants will be asked to provide 10 diary entries (5 authentic experiences on social media, and 5 inauthentic experiences) over a 4-week period. Diary study methods offer advantages for examining day-to-day experiences such as those I wish to examine here. Decisions about whether and how to engage on a particular platform usually occur over time, and may be based on a combination of intense,

memorable experiences and day-to-day encounters that form an impression over time [4].

In order to understand the differences between day-to-day experiences of (in)authenticity and more long-term experiences or perceptions, I also collect recollections from participants. This ability to collect both recollections and in situ experiences is an important benefit of the diary study method. Considering recollections and quotidian experiences in conversation with one another will allow me to better understand how experiences with (in)authenticity shape participants' behavior and engagement on social media platforms.

Participants will also be asked to complete a cognitive mapping exercise. They will be asked to draw a map of how "like themselves" they are online, however they wish to do so and with encouragement to be creative. This exercise serves as a way to allow people to mentally visualize the relationships and interdependencies within their larger social media ecosystem, and has been successfully used in past work to understand LGBTQ+ users' behavior across their social media ecosystem [13].

After completing their recollections, diary entries, and cognitive maps, participants will finally be interviewed. I will use these semi-structured interviews to elicit additional detail based on trends established in the first parts of the study, validating and further investigating emergent analytic concepts while member-checking my interpretations. Purposeful triangulation of multiple methods is an effective way of testing the validity of my findings through the convergence of information from different sources. Using multiple sources of data will allow me to more deeply explore phenomena, enhance my understanding of participants' contexts, and enhance the trustworthiness of my findings [7]. Analysis of the Diary Study will be underway by the time of the Doctoral Consortium.

4 EXPECTED CONTRIBUTIONS

My dissertation will help researchers better understand the role of (in)authenticity in marginalized users' social media ecosystems: how they evaluate new platforms and communities, and how they navigate their existing platforms. This work will provide a solid basis for future theorizing regarding the triggers, experience, and ultimately functions of authenticity in the social media context. It will also provide a more comprehensive and ecologically valid account of the ways in which holding a devalued identity shapes behaviors and experiences, beyond concerns around disclosure and self-presentation.

I expect to see thematic commonalities among LGBTQ+ people's experiences of authenticity and inauthenticity. I am interested in finding out the factors underlying experiences of authenticity and inauthenticity: the presence or absence of certain affordances or interface elements, what user-submitted content people encounter, experiences within a community, or interactions with the privacy and security features of a platform. I will work to draw out participants' perspectives on the relationship between their LGBTQ+ identity and their social media environments, and their strategies for navigating these dynamics within their personal social media ecosystems.

BIOGRAPHICAL SKETCH

I am currently a 4th year PhD candidate in the Media, Technology, and Society program at Northwestern University. My work looks at the ways in which online social spaces impact users' wellbeing and feelings of safety, particularly as it relates to marginalized populations such as LGBTQ+ people. As a Latinx member of the LGBTQ+ community, this is a topic that holds great personal interest to me. After completing my PhD, my hope is to pursue a teaching-focused career, while continuing my research on the creation of equitable technological systems. I am also interested in more direct work creating those systems through qualitative research in the tech industry. Accordingly, I would find mentorship on the design and execution of effective qualitative work (particularly in industry settings) extremely valuable.

I found my way to my dissertation work after publishing a paper that qualitatively explored transgender dating app users' decisions around disclosing their trans status. One key finding from that paper was how the anticipation of harm was so important to understanding these decision-making processes. We also found that, while disclosing trans status was an important strategy to avoid harm and protect participants' safety, this disclosure was often in tension with the equally strong desire to express themselves in a way that felt authentic and human. As a result, I turned my attention to the intersection of safety and authenticity and began the research arc I present in this application.

The diversity of work and perspectives represented at CSCW are ideal for generating new ideas. By the time of the consortium, I will be working on analyzing a rich body of qualitative data. My analyses will benefit greatly from others' perspectives and approaches; I hope to explore sensitizing concepts and analytical considerations I may not have considered in my initial research plan. Finally, I view the consortium as an important opportunity to begin refining how I communicate about my work to different audiences.

FUNDING AND DEMONSTRATIVE PUBLICATIONS

Complete funds for conference fees will be available through my University, should I be accepted to the Doctoral Consortium.

One publication that illustrates my interests is my paper "I Don't Want Them to Not Know": Investigating Decisions to Disclose Transgender Identity on Dating Platforms. One paper that I find inspiring is State authenticity as fit to environment: The implications of social identity for fit, authenticity, and self-segregation by Toni Schmader and Constantine Sedikides, which provides an elegant framework for understanding how environments may hinder marginalized people's ability to feel and act authentic in a setting.

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